

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Supply Chain and Logistics English



Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For supply-chain managers, planners, buyers, logistics coordinators, warehouse leaders, procurement teams, customs staff, and operations managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Demand planning exception

02 A component shortage

03 Inventory accuracy

04 Dock congestion

05 A customs document mismatch

06 Carrier performance review

07 Supplier recovery plan

08 Disruption handoff

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Demand planning exception

Sales and planning review a sudden forecast increase.

Roles: Demand planner / Sales manager

Demand planner: Your forecast doubles next month's demand. Is that confirmed business or pipeline?

Sales manager: Half is a signed promotion; the rest depends on a retailer's decision.

Demand planner: Then I'll separate the committed volume from the upside scenario.

Sales manager: Can procurement reserve capacity for both?

Demand planner: We can ask about options, but a reservation may carry a fee or minimum commitment.

Sales manager: I'll confirm the retailer's decision date and cancellation terms.

Demand planner: Good. We'll review the supply exposure before releasing additional purchase orders.

Sales manager: I'll also remove the duplicate opportunity from the sales forecast.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Your forecast doubles next month's demand. Is that confirmed business or pipeline?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A component shortage

A buyer and planner discuss a late component shipment.

Roles: Buyer / Supply planner

Buyer: The supplier pushed the connector delivery back five days.

Supply planner: Our available stock covers only three production days. Is there a partial shipment?

Buyer: They can offer 600 units early, pending final inspection.

Supply planner: That would protect the priority order. What is the additional freight cost?

Buyer: I'm waiting on the quote. I haven't authorized expedited freight.

Supply planner: Send the quantity, confirmed ship date, and cost together.

Buyer: I'll get a written commitment from the supplier.

Supply planner: I'll model the remaining gap and flag orders needing revised promise dates.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Our available stock covers only three production days. Is there a partial shipment?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Inventory accuracy

A warehouse count differs from the planning system.

Roles: Inventory controller / Warehouse supervisor

Inventory controller: The system shows 480 units, but the cycle count found 430.

Warehouse supervisor: Were the 50 units in the returns cage included?

Inventory controller: They were physically counted separately. Their inspection status is still pending.

Warehouse supervisor: Then they're not available-to-promise stock.

Inventory controller: Right. I need to reconcile the status before requesting an adjustment.

Warehouse supervisor: Check yesterday's transfer and return transactions as well.

Inventory controller: I'll retain both count sheets and investigate the movement history.

Warehouse supervisor: Let planning know that only the verified saleable quantity is available.

Notice the professional language

cycle count - A recurring count of selected inventory items to check record accuracy.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Dock congestion

A warehouse team has more outbound orders than dispatch capacity.

Roles: Warehouse manager / Transport coordinator

Warehouse manager: We have 130 orders still waiting. Which can make today's collection?

Transport coordinator: The carrier has room for 80. The rest need another collection or tomorrow's run.

Warehouse manager: Prioritize the orders with today's committed dispatch date.

Transport coordinator: Some of those aren't picked yet. Can we move them into the next picking wave?

Warehouse manager: Yes. I'll resequence picking without mixing customer labels.

Transport coordinator: I'll request an additional vehicle and confirm the surcharge.

Warehouse manager: Don't promise same-day dispatch until the capacity is confirmed.

Transport coordinator: Agreed. Customer service will receive the final exception list at cutoff.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We have 130 orders still waiting. Which can make today's collection?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A customs document mismatch

A shipment is awaiting clarification at the destination port.

Roles: Customs broker / Logistics coordinator

Customs broker: The commercial invoice and packing list show different quantities.

Logistics coordinator: The invoice lists 100 cartons; the packing list lists 96. I'll check the loading record.

Customs broker: Please obtain corrected documents from the responsible shipper. Don't just edit the figures here.

Logistics coordinator: Does the tariff classification need review too?

Customs broker: The product description is incomplete, so classification needs confirmation from the appropriate specialist.

Logistics coordinator: I'll request the detailed specification and reconcile the carton count.

Customs broker: Once those are available, we can assess the entry requirements.

Logistics coordinator: I'll tell the customer clearance remains pending and avoid promising a delivery date.

Notice the professional language

commercial invoice - A trade document describing the goods sold and relevant transaction details.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Carrier performance review

Procurement challenges a carrier's on-time delivery report.

Roles: Procurement manager / Carrier account manager

Procurement manager: Your scorecard says 96 percent on time. Ours says 89 percent.

Carrier account manager: We measure arrival within the booked delivery day. What window are you using?

Procurement manager: The appointment slot, including rejected deliveries. Are those in your denominator?

Carrier account manager: No. We excluded failed delivery attempts.

Procurement manager: That explains part of the gap. Let's reconcile shipment IDs before discussing remedies.

Carrier account manager: I'll send the event-level records and exclusion rules.

Procurement manager: We'll agree on one definition for next month's review.

Carrier account manager: And I'll separately investigate the repeated misses at the northern distribution center.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We measure arrival within the booked delivery day. What window are you using?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Supplier recovery plan

A supplier has missed two weekly commitments.

Roles: Supplier development lead / Supplier production manager

Supplier development lead: We need a recovery plan tied to actual capacity. What is constraining output?

Supplier production manager: Final test is the bottleneck. The second fixture is still being qualified.

Supplier development lead: What can the current fixture deliver reliably?

Supplier production manager: About 200 units a day on the present shift pattern.

Supplier development lead: Show that as the base plan. Keep the second fixture as a conditional improvement.

Supplier production manager: I'll include daily milestones and the qualification decision date.

Supplier development lead: Please also identify the owner for each action.

Supplier production manager: I'll send the plan today and report shipment quantities against it each morning.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We need a recovery plan tied to actual capacity. What is constraining output?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Disruption handoff

A storm has interrupted a planned delivery route.

Roles: Logistics coordinator / Customer service lead

Logistics coordinator: The linehaul is delayed, and the carrier hasn't confirmed a revised arrival.

Customer service lead: Do we know which customer orders are on the trailer?

Logistics coordinator: Yes. I've attached the manifest and the last verified tracking event.

Customer service lead: Can we offer delivery tomorrow?

Logistics coordinator: Not yet. The alternate route is still being assessed.

Customer service lead: I'll explain the delay and give customers a time for the next update.

Logistics coordinator: I'll own the carrier follow-up and flag any confirmed change immediately.

Customer service lead: I'll record individual customer constraints so we can prioritize when capacity returns.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Do we know which customer orders are on the trailer?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Demand Planning and Forecast Bias

SHARED CASE

A forecast exceeds actual demand for three months. Sales expects a new promotion to improve demand but has no order evidence yet.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The forecast has been above actual demand for three months. The promotion may change that pattern, but it is still an assumption. I'll separate confirmed orders from the promotional estimate.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Procurement and Supplier Performance

SHARED CASE

A supplier acknowledges an order but gives no shipping date. The planning team needs a date to update its schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you confirm the planned ship date and any quantity that will remain outstanding? Please distinguish a confirmed commitment from a provisional estimate so we can update the schedule accurately.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Inventory, Safety Stock, and Service Levels

SHARED CASE

A warehouse has high total inventory but repeated stockouts of two important items. A manager asks why the headline total looks healthy.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The total inventory value hides differences between items. We have stock in some products but shortages in two others. Let's review availability by item and expected demand.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Warehousing and Fulfillment

SHARED CASE

A fulfillment team starts with 300 open orders and ships 220. Fifty new orders arrive during the shift.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

We shipped 220 orders, and 50 new orders arrived. The backlog is now 130 orders. I'll include both completed work and incoming demand so the change is clear.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Freight, Routing, and Carrier Delays

SHARED CASE

A carrier estimates delivery on Wednesday but has not confirmed departure. A customer asks for a guaranteed arrival time.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Wednesday is the carrier's current estimate, not a confirmed arrival. Departure is still pending. I'll send the next update when the carrier confirms the shipment status.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Customs, Trade Compliance, and Documentation

SHARED CASE

A shipment file contains different product descriptions on the invoice and packing list. The broker requests clarification.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The descriptions do not match across the documents. Could the responsible team confirm the correct product details and provide consistent records for the broker's review?

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Supply Risk and Business Continuity

SHARED CASE

One supplier has a shorter lead time; a second has available backup capacity. The team is considering supply continuity options.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The first supplier offers speed, while the second may provide backup capacity. Let's compare availability, qualification status, and switching constraints before treating either option as a complete continuity solution.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Executive S&OP Decisions

SHARED CASE

Sales and operations propose different monthly plans. The meeting has ten minutes left and no agreed assumption about the promotion.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The unresolved assumption is promotional demand. Could we compare the two plans using the same assumption, then record the chosen plan, its owner, and the condition that would trigger a review?

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Three months of overforecast before a promotion

Fictional demand review: the forecast exceeded actual demand for three months; sales expects a promotion to help, but no supporting orders exist yet.

01 • Demand planner: Our forecast exceeded actual demand for three months. That repeated direction suggests an overforecast pattern to review.

02 • Sales manager: The promotion should improve demand. Can we treat the current forecast as confirmed now?

03 • Demand planner: Not yet. We have an expectation about the promotion, but no supporting order evidence.

04 • Sales manager: Does the recent forecast bias prove that the promotion will fail as well?

05 • Demand planner: No. Historical overforecast and the future promotion are different questions, both requiring clear assumptions.

06 • Sales manager: Then I'll describe the promotion uplift as a planning assumption rather than a confirmed demand signal.

07 • Demand planner: Good. We can take a base view and a clearly labeled promotion scenario into S&OP.

08 • Sales manager: What evidence would let us revisit that assumption during the next review?

09 • Demand planner: Verified orders and relevant demand information, with timing and scope clear rather than an optimistic headline.

10 • Sales manager: I'll bring those when available and keep the current expectation separate from actual demand.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A one-time order inside the baseline

Separate fictional planning case: last month's demand included a one-time order of 200 units; whether it will repeat is unconfirmed.

01 • Sales analyst: Last month's actual demand includes the two hundred-unit special order. Should it remain in next month's baseline?

02 • Demand planner: We should identify it separately because repeat demand hasn't been confirmed for that order.

03 • Sales analyst: Could we assume it repeats simply because the customer was pleased with delivery?

04 • Demand planner: Customer satisfaction isn't a confirmed order. Keep any repeat expectation labeled as an assumption.

05 • Sales analyst: Would removing it completely prove that the lower forecast is more accurate?

06 • Demand planner: No. We need a justified planning treatment, not certainty about an outcome that hasn't occurred.

07 • Sales analyst: I'll show the one-time quantity separately and ask sales whether any repeat commitment exists.

08 • Demand planner: That gives S&OP a clearer demand signal and avoids hiding a special event in the baseline.

09 • Sales analyst: I'll distinguish confirmed history from the proposed future treatment in the review.

10 • Demand planner: Good. We'll revisit the assumption when evidence arrives instead of treating one month as a permanent pattern.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Orders shifted between months are not necessarily growth

Separate fictional demand analysis: 80 units originally requested for June were moved to May; no additional quantity was ordered.

01 • Commercial lead: May's orders increased by eighty units. Can we report that as new demand growth?

02 • Demand analyst: Those eighty were moved from June into May; the total ordered quantity didn't increase.

03 • Commercial lead: So we have a timing change in the demand signal rather than eighty incremental units?

04 • Demand analyst: Correct. Treating them as new demand could also leave the June forecast overstated.

05 • Commercial lead: Does the move prove the customer will buy less over the whole quarter?

06 • Demand analyst: No. The supplied change is timing only, not evidence of a different quarterly total.

07 • Commercial lead: I'll explain the pull-forward and keep the two months linked in the forecast discussion.

08 • Demand analyst: Please preserve the original and revised dates so we can trace the change.

09 • Commercial lead: Should we take the timing assumption into S&OP rather than celebrate it as a sales increase?

10 • Demand analyst: Yes. Report the confirmed schedule movement and leave any wider growth interpretation dependent on additional evidence.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Demand Planning and Forecast Bias

A forecast exceeds actual demand for three months. Sales expects a new promotion to improve demand but has no order evidence yet.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The forecast has been above actual demand for three months. The promotion may change that pattern, but it is still an assumption. I'll separate confirmed orders from the promotional estimate.

Scenario 2 | A distributor inquiry mistaken for an order

A fictional distributor asks whether 500 units could be available next month but submits no purchase order. Sales wants to add all 500 as confirmed demand. Discuss the distinction and an appropriately labeled planning scenario.

Role A: Demand planner: distinguish the inquiry from a commitment.

Role B: Account manager: explain the potential opportunity and agree how to obtain a clearer demand signal.

Possible opening: The five hundred units are an availability inquiry, not a confirmed order yet.

Success checks

- Keep inquiry quantity separate from committed demand.
- Avoid predicting whether the order will materialize.
- Agree a labeled scenario and a specific confirmation request.

Add a complication: The sales lead says a confident tone from the distributor is enough evidence.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An acknowledgment without a shipping date

Fictional procurement call: the supplier acknowledged purchase order 612 but provided no shipping date; the planning review is tomorrow afternoon.

01 • Buyer: Thank you for acknowledging purchase order six twelve. Please confirm the shipping date or current constraint.

02 • Supplier coordinator: The acknowledgment confirms receipt of the order, not a committed dispatch date yet.

03 • Buyer: We need a date for tomorrow afternoon's planning review. Can you check and return a status before noon?

04 • Supplier coordinator: I can check with planning this morning and confirm when a reliable update is available.

05 • Buyer: Please distinguish a firm commitment from an estimated lead time in that response.

06 • Supplier coordinator: Understood. I won't turn the standard lead time into a confirmed shipping promise.

07 • Buyer: If allocation is limiting the order, please identify the affected quantity rather than simply say delayed.

08 • Supplier coordinator: I'll ask for that detail, but the current cause isn't confirmed, so I won't assume allocation.

09 • Buyer: Thank you. I'll keep our downstream schedule provisional until we receive the verified status.

10 • Supplier coordinator: Request accepted. I'll return the planning response or explain the remaining uncertainty before your review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A partial shipment needs a quantity and date

Separate fictional supplier case: order 733 is for 400 units; the supplier offers a partial shipment without specifying quantity or dispatch date.

01 • Procurement specialist: You offered a partial shipment against the four hundred units on order seven thirty-three. Please specify quantity and dispatch date.

02 • Supplier account manager: Those details aren't confirmed yet. I can ask our allocation team for the available quantity.

03 • Procurement specialist: Could you also confirm the balance plan so we can assess the offer before accepting it?

04 • Supplier account manager: Yes. Would you accept any available quantity now and leave the remainder open?

05 • Procurement specialist: We need the actual split and timing first; otherwise we can't evaluate the impact on our schedule.

06 • Supplier account manager: I'll request both the proposed first shipment and the remaining commitment from planning.

07 • Procurement specialist: Please return an initial status today, even if the quantities remain unconfirmed.

08 • Supplier account manager: I can provide that status by the end of our working day without promising shipment.

09 • Procurement specialist: Agreed. We are requesting details, not accepting an undefined partial-delivery arrangement.

10 • Supplier account manager: Understood. I'll label estimates clearly and wait for your reviewed response to the complete proposal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Confirm the OTIF measure before the supplier review

Separate fictional performance meeting: the buyer calculates OTIF by order, while the supplier's presentation calculates it by order line; the joint review is Friday.

01 • Supplier performance analyst: Before Friday's review, please confirm the denominator and delivery basis used in your OTIF presentation.

02 • Supplier representative: Our on-time, in-full figure is calculated by order line. Is your report using the same unit?

03 • Supplier performance analyst: No, ours uses whole orders, so the two percentages aren't directly comparable.

04 • Supplier representative: Would you like us to replace our number with yours before the meeting?

05 • Supplier performance analyst: Please provide the underlying order-line data and definition first so we can reconcile both views.

06 • Supplier representative: I can ask our analyst to prepare that. What timing would support your review?

07 • Supplier performance analyst: An initial data-availability confirmation tomorrow would help us agree a realistic reconciliation schedule.

08 • Supplier representative: I'll confirm availability tomorrow, but I can't promise the reconciled calculation before assessing the work.

09 • Supplier performance analyst: That's fine. Keep the current definition visible rather than present either number as the agreed result.

10 • Supplier representative: Request received. We'll distinguish our existing measure from the common basis still to be agreed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Procurement and Supplier Performance

A supplier acknowledges an order but gives no shipping date. The planning team needs a date to update its schedule.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you confirm the planned ship date and any quantity that will remain outstanding? Please distinguish a confirmed commitment from a provisional estimate so we can update the schedule accurately.

Scenario 2 | Lead time without a starting point

A fictional supplier quotes ten working days but does not say whether the clock starts at order receipt or technical approval. Approval has not occurred. Request a precise lead-time definition before updating the schedule.

Role A: Buyer: ask for the start event, delivery milestone, and current order status.

Role B: Supplier planner: acknowledge the ambiguity and arrange confirmation without inventing a shipment date.

Possible opening: When you say ten working days, does that start at order receipt or technical approval?

Success checks

- Clarify the lead-time starting event and endpoint.
- Separate acknowledgment from technical approval.
- Agree a confirmation response before making a dated commitment.

Add a complication: The internal planner has already counted ten days from yesterday's acknowledgment.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

High total stock with two recurring stockouts

Fictional inventory review: total inventory is high, but two important SKUs repeatedly stock out; item-level demand and stock policies need review.

01 • Operations manager: Our total inventory looks healthy. Why are two important items still experiencing stockouts?

02 • Inventory planner: The total combines different SKUs; stock of one item doesn't necessarily satisfy demand for another.

03 • Operations manager: So a large aggregate can hide the wrong mix of inventory across the product range?

04 • Inventory planner: Exactly. We need item-level availability and demand, not only the total value or quantity.

05 • Operations manager: Would increasing safety stock everywhere automatically solve the service-level problem?

06 • Inventory planner: Not necessarily. We should assess the affected items and their replenishment conditions before proposing changes.

07 • Operations manager: Can you explain SKU for the newer colleague joining this review?

08 • Inventory planner: It means stock-keeping unit, the identifier for a particular stocked item in our system.

09 • Operations manager: I'll ask for separate results for the two items rather than treat the headline as reassurance.

10 • Inventory planner: I'll bring the verified item-level picture and keep any policy recommendation tied to the actual evidence.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

On-hand stock versus stock available to promise

Separate fictional inventory case: SKU Q5 has 100 units on hand, of which 70 are already allocated; no other holds or receipts are included.

01 • Customer service lead: Q5 shows one hundred units on hand. Can I promise all one hundred to this new customer?

02 • Inventory controller: Seventy are already allocated, leaving thirty unallocated in this simplified case.

03 • Customer service lead: So on-hand quantity and quantity available for a new promise are different measures?

04 • Inventory controller: Yes. We must account for existing commitments instead of treating the same units as available twice.

05 • Customer service lead: Could safety stock be counted again as an extra pool outside the one hundred?

06 • Inventory controller: Not without the actual stock definition. Safety stock is not automatically additional physical inventory beyond that count.

07 • Customer service lead: I'll explain that thirty are unallocated here, while any customer commitment still follows our order process.

08 • Inventory controller: Good. Don't invent future receipts to make the requested quantity fit.

09 • Customer service lead: I'll check the customer's required quantity and timing before offering a confirmed option.

10 • Inventory controller: I'll verify the current allocation status so the final promise uses the right SKU and stock basis.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A service percentage needs its denominator

Separate fictional service review: nine of ten orders shipped complete, but those nine contained only half of the units ordered in total.

01 • Sales manager: Nine out of ten orders shipped complete. Can I say we fulfilled ninety percent of all units?

02 • Supply analyst: No. That is an order-based measure; the nine complete orders contained only half of the units ordered.

03 • Sales manager: Then the same fulfillment performance can look different when measured by orders rather than units?

04 • Supply analyst: Correct. Each measure answers a different service question, so the denominator must be named.

05 • Sales manager: Does the remaining order automatically count as a total stockout for every SKU it contains?

06 • Supply analyst: We don't have that detail. Don't infer item-level availability from the aggregate order status.

07 • Sales manager: I'll describe the ninety percent as complete-order performance, not the share of units supplied.

08 • Supply analyst: We need the quantity shipped on the incomplete order before calculating unit fulfillment.

09 • Sales manager: I'll ask for the item breakdown before discussing safety-stock changes with the team.

10 • Supply analyst: Good. A precise service-level definition helps us identify the actual problem without turning one percentage into a universal success claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Inventory, Safety Stock, and Service Levels

A warehouse has high total inventory but repeated stockouts of two important items. A manager asks why the headline total looks healthy.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: The total inventory value hides differences between items. We have stock in some products but shortages in two others. Let's review availability by item and expected demand.

Scenario 2 | An incoming delivery mistaken for current stock

A fictional SKU has 20 units physically on hand and 80 expected next week. The expected receipt is not confirmed. A screen combines them as 100 planned units. Explain current availability without making a shipment promise.

Role A: Inventory controller: separate present stock from the expected receipt.

Role B: Customer service coordinator: ask what can be verified before offering an order commitment.

Possible opening: Only twenty units are currently on hand; the other eighty are an unconfirmed expected receipt.

Success checks

- Keep present and expected quantities separate.
- Do not assume current stock is unallocated unless checked.
- Agree the allocation and receipt checks needed before a promise.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the combined total available inventory.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The backlog is 130, not 80

Fictional fulfillment shift: 300 orders were open at the start, 220 shipped, and 50 new orders arrived; there were no other order-status changes.

01 • Fulfillment supervisor: We shipped two hundred twenty orders from a starting backlog of three hundred.

02 • Operations manager: Then eighty orders remain open at the end of the shift, correct?

03 • Fulfillment supervisor: Fifty new orders also arrived, so the closing backlog is one hundred thirty.

04 • Operations manager: Thank you. I subtracted shipments but missed the new work entering the queue.

05 • Fulfillment supervisor: The complete flow is three hundred plus fifty, minus two hundred twenty, with no other changes.

06 • Operations manager: Does the shipment count tell us the pick rate for the team?

07 • Fulfillment supervisor: Not by itself. We need the picking measure and time basis before making that calculation.

08 • Operations manager: I'll report the verified closing backlog and keep any productivity interpretation separate.

09 • Fulfillment supervisor: I'll also identify which open orders need review without assuming all one hundred thirty are late.

10 • Operations manager: Good. The status update should distinguish unfinished orders from confirmed service failures and completed shipments.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Picked is not shipped

Separate fictional warehouse update: 75 orders are picked, 60 of those are packed, and none have confirmed carrier handover yet.

01 • Warehouse coordinator: Seventy-five orders are picked, and sixty of those are packed. Carrier handover isn't confirmed yet.

02 • Customer operations lead: Can I tell customers that all seventy-five have shipped because picking is complete?

03 • Warehouse coordinator: No. Picking, packing, and shipping are separate stages, and handover remains unconfirmed.

04 • Customer operations lead: Then fifteen picked orders still need packing, while sixty are further along but not confirmed shipped?

05 • Warehouse coordinator: Correct. The stages are nested counts here, so don't add them together as separate orders.

06 • Customer operations lead: Would a high pick rate justify promising that the remaining work will finish within an hour?

07 • Warehouse coordinator: Not without checking the current capacity and handover schedule. That completion time isn't supplied.

08 • Customer operations lead: I'll give a stage-based update and keep the delivery message conditional on verified dispatch.

09 • Warehouse coordinator: I'll request the next packing and carrier-status checkpoint from the responsible leads.

10 • Customer operations lead: Thanks. We'll communicate completed work accurately without turning preparation progress into a shipment confirmation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Cycle counting covers only the checked locations

Separate fictional warehouse exercise: a cycle count covered 12 of 20 planned locations; eight remain uncounted, and reconciliation of the counted locations is pending.

01 • Inventory supervisor: We've counted twelve of the twenty planned locations. Eight remain, and reconciliation is still pending.

02 • Warehouse manager: Can I mark the inventory check complete because more than half the locations are done?

03 • Inventory supervisor: No. The count scope and reconciliation work are not complete, even though field counting has progressed.

04 • Warehouse manager: Do the eight uncounted locations indicate eight missing items in the backlog?

05 • Inventory supervisor: No. Uncounted locations are unfinished work, not evidence of missing stock.

06 • Warehouse manager: I'll separate locations counted, locations pending, and reconciliation status in the update.

07 • Inventory supervisor: Please also avoid using this partial count as proof that the new slotting plan is accurate.

08 • Warehouse manager: That comparison would need its own evidence. What can you confirm at the next checkpoint?

09 • Inventory supervisor: I'll provide the verified counting progress and any reconciled findings, keeping unresolved differences separate.

10 • Warehouse manager: Agreed. We'll update fulfillment planning from confirmed inventory information rather than treat partial coverage as a completed audit.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Warehousing and Fulfillment

A fulfillment team starts with 300 open orders and ships 220. Fifty new orders arrive during the shift.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: We shipped 220 orders, and 50 new orders arrived. The backlog is now 130 orders. I'll include both completed work and incoming demand so the change is clear.

Scenario 2 | A returned order reenters the work queue

A fictional shift begins with 90 open orders, ships 40, and receives 10 returned orders requiring new fulfillment work. No new sales orders arrive. Explain the closing work queue under this supplied counting rule.

Role A: Fulfillment lead: report the 60-order closing queue and distinguish returns from new sales.

Role B: Operations analyst: check the arithmetic and ask how the returned work is labeled.

Possible opening: The closing queue is sixty: ninety minus forty shipped, plus ten returned orders needing work.

Success checks

- Calculate the closing queue as sixty under the stated rule.
- Distinguish returned work from new sales orders.
- Avoid inferring return causes or stock availability.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to count the ten returns as new customer demand.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Wednesday is an estimate before departure

Fictional freight call: the carrier estimates Wednesday delivery but has not confirmed departure; the customer requests a guaranteed arrival time.

01 • Customer service manager: The customer wants a guaranteed arrival time. Can we promise Wednesday based on the carrier's ETA?

02 • Transport planner: Wednesday is an estimate, and departure hasn't been confirmed, so I can't guarantee arrival.

03 • Customer service manager: Does the estimate at least establish that the shipment is already moving?

04 • Transport planner: No. An estimated arrival and a verified departure are different pieces of information.

05 • Customer service manager: I'll say Wednesday is the current estimate, subject to confirmation, with departure still unverified.

06 • Transport planner: That matches what we know. We can request a departure update from the carrier.

07 • Customer service manager: Would asking to expedite automatically make the original estimate a guaranteed commitment?

08 • Transport planner: No. Any alternative service and its conditions would need confirmation before we communicate them.

09 • Customer service manager: I'll keep the customer's urgency visible without making a promise the evidence doesn't support.

10 • Transport planner: I'll return the verified carrier status and distinguish any revised estimate from a firm service commitment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A tracking scan is not proof of delivery

Separate fictional shipment case: tracking shows arrival at a regional hub at 06:00; no delivery scan or recipient confirmation exists.

01 • Account coordinator: The shipment arrived at six. Can I tell the customer delivery is complete?

02 • Freight specialist: The scan says regional hub arrival at six, not arrival at the customer's location.

03 • Account coordinator: I shortened the status too far. What can we state without guessing the remaining route?

04 • Freight specialist: It reached the regional hub; final delivery is unconfirmed in the available tracking information.

05 • Account coordinator: Does the missing delivery scan prove the carrier failed to deliver it?

06 • Freight specialist: Not necessarily. We need confirmation rather than infer either completion or failure from the missing scan.

07 • Account coordinator: I'll correct my message and ask for the latest delivery status and ETA.

08 • Freight specialist: Please keep the scan location and time attached so the source of the update is clear.

09 • Account coordinator: I won't invent an out-for-delivery status to reassure the customer while we wait.

10 • Freight specialist: Good. I'll contact the carrier and relay confirmed events separately from estimates or unresolved tracking gaps.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An expedite quote is only one part of the option

Separate fictional freight exercise: a carrier quotes an expedited service price but has not confirmed collection capacity or delivery commitment.

01 • Purchasing manager: We have an expedite price. Can I tell operations the delay is solved if we accept it?

02 • Transport coordinator: Not yet. Collection capacity and the delivery commitment remain unconfirmed, despite the quoted price.

03 • Purchasing manager: So a price offer doesn't establish that the carrier can execute the proposed movement?

04 • Transport coordinator: Correct. We need the operational terms as well as the cost before describing the option as available.

05 • Purchasing manager: Could we assume the existing incoterms answer every responsibility question for the expedited arrangement?

06 • Transport coordinator: We should check the actual agreed terms and proposed change rather than assume their application.

07 • Purchasing manager: I'll describe the quote as received, with service availability and responsibilities still under review.

08 • Transport coordinator: Please avoid promising a new ETA until the carrier provides the relevant confirmation.

09 • Purchasing manager: I'll request that information before asking the decision maker to approve the option.

10 • Transport coordinator: I'll assess the returned service details and separate a possible recovery route from a verified transport commitment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Freight, Routing, and Carrier Delays

A carrier estimates delivery on Wednesday but has not confirmed departure. A customer asks for a guaranteed arrival time.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: Wednesday is the carrier's current estimate, not a confirmed arrival. Departure is still pending. I'll send the next update when the carrier confirms the shipment status.

Scenario 2 | Two ETA messages with different timestamps

A fictional carrier portal shows Friday delivery in an update from yesterday. A later email says Thursday estimated delivery but provides no departure confirmation. Discuss the latest estimate and remaining uncertainty without claiming a guaranteed date.

Role A: Transport planner: identify the later estimate and its unconfirmed basis.

Role B: Customer coordinator: ask what carrier confirmation is still needed.

Possible opening: The later message estimates Thursday, but neither message confirms departure or guarantees delivery.

Success checks

- State the message timing and estimated status.
- Do not treat a later estimate as a delivery guarantee.
- Agree a carrier clarification and an accurately qualified customer update.

Add a complication: The customer asks you to choose the earlier date and remove the word estimated.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two product descriptions in one shipment file

Fictional trade-document review: the commercial invoice and packing list describe the product differently; the broker requests clarification before proceeding.

01 • Customs broker: The commercial invoice and packing list use different product descriptions. Which description is supported by the source records?

02 • Shipping coordinator: I need the product team to verify that; I shouldn't choose whichever wording looks easier to process.

03 • Customs broker: Please provide the relevant item reference and the verified description through the authorized documentation route.

04 • Shipping coordinator: Would changing both documents to the shorter phrase settle the discrepancy without further review?

05 • Customs broker: Not if the phrase is unverified. Consistent wording still needs to describe the actual goods accurately.

06 • Shipping coordinator: I'll request source confirmation and preserve the conflicting documents for the review.

07 • Customs broker: Also keep any HS-code or country-of-origin question separate unless that information is actually confirmed.

08 • Shipping coordinator: Understood. A description correction doesn't automatically establish the classification or origin.

09 • Customs broker: Please return the verified clarification so the responsible team can assess the next documentation step.

10 • Shipping coordinator: I'll do that and keep shipment status qualified rather than promise clearance before the review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Shipping location is not automatically country of origin

Separate fictional documentation case: goods ship from warehouse A, but their manufacturing origin is not supplied; the form asks for country of origin.

01 • Export coordinator: The goods leave warehouse A. Can I enter its country as the country of origin?

02 • Trade compliance specialist: Not from shipping location alone. We need the relevant origin information for the actual goods.

03 • Export coordinator: Which source should I request rather than infer origin from the warehouse address?

04 • Trade compliance specialist: Ask the responsible supplier or product records team for the supporting origin documentation and applicable review.

05 • Export coordinator: Could the commercial invoice address settle it even if it is only the seller's office?

06 • Trade compliance specialist: No. A seller address doesn't automatically establish origin either.

07 • Export coordinator: I'll mark the field as requiring verification and send the item references with my request.

08 • Trade compliance specialist: Good. Don't select a country simply to make the documentation look complete.

09 • Export coordinator: I'll ask the broker what verified information is needed before the shipment file proceeds.

10 • Trade compliance specialist: I'll coordinate the review and keep any legal origin determination with the qualified specialists for the actual context.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A code copied from a similar item

Separate fictional classification discussion: a draft invoice copies an HS code from a similar-looking item; material and function details for the new item are incomplete.

01 • Logistics assistant: I copied the HS code from a similar item. Is that enough for this draft invoice?

02 • Trade specialist: Similarity in appearance doesn't confirm classification. What material and function information do we have for the new item?

03 • Logistics assistant: Those details are incomplete, so I can't show that the two items share the relevant characteristics.

04 • Trade specialist: Then request the product information and have the classification reviewed rather than carry the copied code forward as confirmed.

05 • Logistics assistant: Should I ask the broker to choose a code based only on the product photo?

06 • Trade specialist: Ask what supporting information they need; don't assume the photo is sufficient for the assessment.

07 • Logistics assistant: I'll identify the copied entry as unverified and request the missing material and function details.

08 • Trade specialist: Please retain the item reference so the reviewed answer is linked to the correct goods.

09 • Logistics assistant: I'll return the verified information before treating the commercial invoice as finalized.

10 • Trade specialist: Good. We'll keep the clarification process separate from any unsupported assurance about duties or customs clearance.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Customs, Trade Compliance, and Documentation

A shipment file contains different product descriptions on the invoice and packing list. The broker requests clarification.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: The descriptions do not match across the documents. Could the responsible team confirm the correct product details and provide consistent records for the broker's review?

Scenario 2 | A package count and a unit count appear to conflict

A fictional packing list says 12 cartons while the commercial invoice says 240 units. The units per carton are not specified. The broker asks whether quantities conflict. Clarify the measurement basis before changing either document.

Role A: Shipping coordinator: identify the different counting units and request the verified pack configuration.

Role B: Customs broker: explain the missing relationship without assuming an error or conversion.

Possible opening: One document counts cartons and the other counts units; we need the verified packing quantity to compare them.

Success checks

- Distinguish cartons from individual units.
- Do not infer packing configuration solely from matching arithmetic.
- Agree a source-backed clarification before document correction.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests assuming twenty units per carton because the arithmetic fits.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Shorter lead time versus available backup capacity

Fictional continuity discussion: supplier A has a shorter lead time; supplier B has available backup capacity. Other comparative details are unconfirmed.

01 • Supply manager: Supplier A is faster. Should we exclude B from the continuity discussion?

02 • Risk planner: B has available backup capacity, so lead time alone doesn't describe the business-continuity tradeoff.

03 • Supply manager: Which common criteria should we use without pretending we already know the full comparison?

04 • Risk planner: Lead time, usable capacity, qualification status, and relevant supply constraints, with unknown entries marked clearly.

05 • Supply manager: Can we call B fully interchangeable just because its capacity is available?

06 • Risk planner: No. Capacity doesn't establish that its supply meets our requirements or is authorized for use.

07 • Supply manager: Then dual sourcing is an option to assess, not a completed resilience measure.

08 • Risk planner: Exactly. Compare the evidence and dependencies before promising that backup supply eliminates disruption risk.

09 • Supply manager: I'll present A's shorter lead time and B's capacity alongside the missing checks.

10 • Risk planner: I'll organize the like-for-like assessment so the decision maker sees both the known advantage and the unresolved conditions.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Two suppliers with one shared transport constraint

Separate fictional continuity case: suppliers C and D are separate companies but both proposed routes use the same port; alternate routing has not been assessed.

01 • Procurement director: We have two suppliers. Can the continuity slide say the route risk is diversified?

02 • Logistics risk analyst: Both proposed routes use the same port, so that particular constraint is still shared.

03 • Procurement director: Does that mean having two suppliers provides no continuity benefit at all?

04 • Logistics risk analyst: Not necessarily. Supplier dependence and transport-route dependence are different aspects to compare.

05 • Procurement director: What should our options table show so neither benefit nor limitation is hidden?

06 • Logistics risk analyst: Supplier capacity, route dependencies, lead times, and any verified alternatives under the same assumptions.

07 • Procurement director: We haven't assessed another port, so I shouldn't list rerouting as immediately available.

08 • Logistics risk analyst: Correct. Treat it as an assessment option with unconfirmed feasibility and timing.

09 • Procurement director: I'll qualify the dual-sourcing statement and request the route comparison before presenting the plan as complete.

10 • Logistics risk analyst: I'll show the shared constraint explicitly and avoid suggesting that two company names remove every common exposure.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A backup allocation smaller than the required volume

Separate fictional planning case: the continuity requirement is 1,000 units; backup supplier E offers a confirmed allocation of 300. Additional capacity is unknown.

01 • Continuity planner: Supplier E has confirmed three hundred units against our thousand-unit requirement.

02 • Operations director: Can we describe that supplier as a complete backup for the month?

03 • Continuity planner: No. The confirmed allocation covers three hundred, leaving seven hundred units without a confirmed backup here.

04 • Operations director: Would it be fair to dismiss the option because it doesn't cover the entire requirement?

05 • Continuity planner: Not necessarily. It offers partial coverage; compare that benefit with cost, timing, and other unresolved constraints.

06 • Operations director: Should we assume the supplier can expand to a thousand if the disruption actually happens?

07 • Continuity planner: No. Additional capacity is unknown and needs confirmation before it enters the committed plan.

08 • Operations director: I'll describe the partial allocation accurately and ask what other reviewed options could cover the gap.

09 • Continuity planner: I'll compare those options against the same thousand-unit requirement rather than change the denominator.

10 • Operations director: Good. Our business-continuity discussion should show both confirmed coverage and the exposure that remains.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Supply Risk and Business Continuity

One supplier has a shorter lead time; a second has available backup capacity. The team is considering supply continuity options.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The first supplier offers speed, while the second may provide backup capacity. Let's compare availability, qualification status, and switching constraints before treating either option as a complete continuity solution.

Scenario 2 | Inventory buffer versus a second supply source

A fictional team can assess either extra inventory or a second supplier. The extra inventory requires storage space that is unconfirmed; the supplier requires qualification that is incomplete. No costs or lead times are supplied. Compare the dependencies without choosing from invented numbers.

Role A: Supply planner: explain the different mechanisms and unresolved conditions.

Role B: Continuity manager: ask for common criteria and identify the next evidence needs.

Possible opening: The inventory option depends on storage, while the second-source option depends on qualification.

Success checks

- Compare both options against the same continuity requirement.
- Keep storage, qualification, timing, and cost unknown where unsupplied.
- Agree evidence gathering without promising risk elimination.

Add a complication: A sponsor wants to label the second source risk-free before qualification finishes.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Ten minutes to surface the promotion assumption

Fictional S&OP meeting: ten minutes remain. Sales proposes 1,200 monthly units after two retailer inquiries suggesting 200 promotional units, but neither retailer has ordered. Operations has confirmed capacity for 1,000 units; overtime capacity is unconfirmed. Both teams can check their assumptions before tomorrow's review. Director Maya approves the monthly plan.

01 • S&OP chair: We have ten minutes. Sales proposes twelve hundred units; operations plans one thousand.

02 • Sales planning lead: Two retailers asked about promotion stock, so we expect two hundred additional units, but neither has ordered.

03 • S&OP chair: Operations, what constrains the higher scenario, and which capacity is actually confirmed?

04 • Operations lead: We have capacity for one thousand units. Overtime capacity for the extra two hundred is unconfirmed.

05 • S&OP chair: Then inquiries support an opportunity, not confirmed demand. Sales, will you verify the proposed uplift?

06 • Sales planning lead: Yes. I'll ask both retailers for quantity and timing confirmation before tomorrow's review.

07 • S&OP chair: Operations, will you check additional capacity against that same monthly horizon?

08 • Operations lead: I'll own that check and report verified capacity tomorrow, keeping any overtime assumption explicit.

09 • S&OP chair: We have two scenarios and two verification owners. Director Maya retains approval of the monthly plan.

10 • Sales planning lead: Agreed. I'll bring the retailer responses; neither scenario is a consensus commitment yet.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A plan labeled consensus before finance speaks

Separate fictional planning meeting: sales and operations support a proposed volume, but finance has not assessed the cash assumption; the chair must clarify decision status.

01 • S&OP facilitator: Sales and operations support the volume, but finance hasn't assessed the cash assumption. This isn't yet a complete consensus plan.

02 • Finance partner: Thank you. I need the purchase timing before I can evaluate the cash implication.

03 • S&OP facilitator: Please explain that dependency, then we'll ask procurement to confirm the proposed timing.

04 • Finance partner: The volume alone doesn't tell us when commitments or payments occur in this scenario.

05 • S&OP facilitator: Can we record your review as pending instead of treating your silence as agreement?

06 • Finance partner: Yes. I'm not rejecting the plan; I'm identifying missing information needed for my assessment.

07 • S&OP facilitator: I'll ask procurement to own the timing clarification and confirm when you can review it.

08 • Finance partner: Once the timing is available, I can give a realistic assessment schedule rather than promise an immediate conclusion.

09 • S&OP facilitator: We'll keep the plan proposed and confirm the decision owner after the relevant inputs are heard.

10 • Finance partner: Agreed. Today's next step is the timing clarification, not an invented finance approval.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Different planning horizons in the same vote

Separate fictional executive meeting: sales proposes a one-month plan while operations presents a three-month plan; participants are about to vote without aligning the horizon.

01 • Planning chair: Before we vote, sales is discussing one month and operations is presenting three months.

02 • Operations lead: You're right. Our capacity assumptions cover the quarter, so the proposals aren't aligned.

03 • Planning chair: Let's agree the decision horizon first, then compare the relevant monthly scenario on the same basis.

04 • Operations lead: Could the group simply choose the larger number and treat that as the consensus plan?

05 • Planning chair: That would hide the different time frames rather than resolve the planning question.

06 • Operations lead: I'll separate our first-month view from the remaining two months for the discussion.

07 • Planning chair: Thank you. We'll then invite sales to confirm its demand assumption for that same month.

08 • Operations lead: Who should retain ownership of the quarterly questions that remain outside today's decision?

09 • Planning chair: I'll confirm a named follow-up owner with the group and record those questions as unresolved.

10 • Operations lead: Good. We can reach a bounded planning outcome without treating unmatched horizons as comparable options.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Executive S&OP Decisions

Sales and operations propose different monthly plans. The meeting has ten minutes left and no agreed assumption about the promotion.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: The unresolved assumption is promotional demand. Could we compare the two plans using the same assumption, then record the chosen plan, its owner, and the condition that would trigger a review?

Scenario 2 | A decision without an action owner

A fictional S&OP meeting agrees to assess a promotion scenario by next Tuesday, but nobody accepts responsibility for consolidating the inputs. Sales owns demand information and operations owns capacity information. Facilitate assignment of the missing coordination role.

Role A: Meeting facilitator: distinguish agreement to assess from ownership of the assessment.

Role B: Planning manager: clarify dependencies and accept or explicitly negotiate the coordination responsibility.

Possible opening: We agreed to assess the scenario by Tuesday, but we still need an owner to bring the inputs together.

Success checks

- Identify the demand and capacity contributors.
- Obtain explicit acceptance or clarification of the coordinating role.
- Restate the Tuesday assessment target without calling the scenario an approved plan.

Add a complication: A participant says everyone owns it and wants to end the meeting immediately.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Supply Chain and Logistics English

Professional audience: supply-chain managers, planners, buyers, logistics coordinators, warehouse leaders, procurement teams, customs staff, and operations managers

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Dialogue 01: Demand planning exception

Original fictional setting: Sales and planning review a sudden forecast increase.

Professional roles: Demand planner / Sales manager

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Demand planner: Your forecast doubles next month's demand. Is that confirmed business or pipeline?

Sales manager: Half is a signed promotion; the rest depends on a retailer's decision.

Demand planner: Then I'll separate the committed volume from the upside scenario.

Sales manager: Can procurement reserve capacity for both?

Demand planner: We can ask about options, but a reservation may carry a fee or minimum commitment.

Sales manager: I'll confirm the retailer's decision date and cancellation terms.

Demand planner: Good. We'll review the supply exposure before releasing additional purchase orders.

Sales manager: I'll also remove the duplicate opportunity from the sales forecast.

Vocabulary in this exchange: forecast: Forward-looking estimate based on assumptions, trends, constraints, and known risks. / scenario: A description of possible conditions used to explore decisions or practice responses.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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Sales manager: I'll also remove the duplicate opportunity from the sales forecast.

Vocabulary in this exchange: forecast: Forward-looking estimate based on assumptions, trends, constraints, and known risks. / scenario: A description of possible conditions used to explore decisions or practice responses.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level